on both sides and measured actions until we reach the point where the past can really be put behind us."[268]

Softer words and measured action, however, were not in the cards. After the US informed India that no aid would be forthcoming for the current year and there was only a provisional request for FY1973, India told the US to reduce the number of USAID personnel in India.[269] There was increased Indian criticism of US actions in Vietnam, including "formal condemnation" from Swaran Singh in parliament and critical comments from Gandhi in Europe.[270] India was also more disapproving of any American presence in the Indian Ocean—a couple of years earlier, Delhi might have seen this presence as a source of stability; it was now seen as a potential source of conflict. Furthermore, Gandhi was more vocal about her concerns about external political interference in Indian domestic politics. These apprehensions had dated back to 1967, but she was much more assertive on this front, convinced that the US was trying to weaken India and her government, and that such an approach also brought her political benefits.[271]

The idea that the US wanted to constrain India took hold. The American refusal to resume aid was seen as further evidence of this, and Jha said, moving forward, India needed to plan assuming no US aid.[272] That summer, India and Pakistan reached an agreement in Shimla, but there was also a sense in Delhi that American and Chinese support was increasing President Bhutto's continued "intransigence."[273]

The Soviet ambassador in India played on Gandhi's concerns about joint Sino-US action contrary to India's interests, urging Delhi to work with Moscow to "frustrat[e] the plots."[274] Soviet officials reported that China had sent Pakistan tanks and fighter aircraft, as well as other military equipment that year, and that Nixon had agreed to supply Pakistan militarily through intermediaries.[275]

Worried about what was transpiring between China and the US, India, on its part, worked to ensure continued Soviet support. Even as Nixon had been in Beijing, Delhi had sent a delegation to Moscow for defense talks.[276]

But it was wary of overdependence on Moscow—and the demands that came with it. Just before the delegation's trip, Gandhi had publicly asserted that India remained nonaligned.[277] During their visit, the Soviet defense minister had wanted to upgrade and operationalize the treaty, suggesting